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The Language of Sustainability Chapter 1: Framing in Sustainability Communication

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Learning Module One: Framing in Sustainability Communication

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Executive Summary

Framing theory has emerged as a crucial concept in sustainability communication, providing valuable insights into how environmental issues are presented, perceived, and acted upon. This report explores the theoretical background of framing within the context of sustainability, examining its origins, key concepts, and applications in environmental communication.

The report begins by outlining the foundational concepts of framing theory, drawing from seminal works by Erving Goffman and Robert Entman. It then delves into four primary framing dimensions that have been identified as particularly relevant to sustainability communication:

1. **Gain vs. Loss Frames:** Research shows that gain frames are more effective for promoting climate change mitigation efforts, while loss frames are more impactful for adaptation strategies.
2. **Individual vs. Collective Action Frames:** These frames focus on whether environmental responsibility is portrayed as personal or societal. Both have their strengths and limitations, with effectiveness often depending on the specific context and audience.
3. **Present vs. Future Frames:** The temporal framing of environmental issues can significantly impact engagement. Present frames can create urgency and emotional engagement, while future frames can inspire long-term thinking and transformative changes.
4. **Local vs. Global Frames:** The geographical scale at which environmental issues are presented can affect public response. Local frames can make issues personally relevant, while global frames can convey the scale and complexity of environmental challenges.

Each framing dimension is explored in detail, discussing its characteristics, effectiveness, and potential limitations. The report highlights that the choice of frame often depends on various factors, including the specific environmental issue, target audience, cultural context, and communication goals.

Key findings suggest that effective sustainability communication often requires a nuanced approach that balances different framing dimensions. For instance, combining local and global perspectives, or linking present actions to future outcomes, can create more impactful messages.

The report concludes that by understanding and strategically applying these framing concepts, communicators can more effectively engage audiences and promote sustainable behaviors and policies. This nuanced approach to framing can play a crucial role in addressing complex environmental challenges and driving meaningful progress in sustainability efforts.

Introduction

Framing theory has emerged as a crucial concept in the field of sustainability communication, offering valuable insights into how environmental issues are presented, perceived, and acted upon. This report explores the theoretical background of framing within the context of sustainability, examining its origins, key concepts, and applications in environmental communication. By delving into four primary framing dimensions - Gain vs. Loss, Individual vs. Collective Action, Present vs. Future, and Local vs. Global - we aim to provide a comprehensive understanding of how these frames shape public perception and engagement with sustainability issues.

The report begins by outlining the foundational concepts of framing theory, drawing from seminal works in sociology, psychology, and communication studies. It then examines each framing dimension in detail, discussing their characteristics, effectiveness, and potential limitations. Throughout the report, we highlight relevant research findings and practical implications for sustainability communicators. By understanding the nuances of framing in sustainability discourse, communicators can more effectively engage audiences and promote sustainable behaviors and policies.

What is framing Theory?

Framing theory has become increasingly important in the field of sustainability communication, offering valuable insights into how environmental issues are presented, perceived, and acted upon. This report explores the theoretical background of framing within the context of sustainability, examining its origins, key concepts, and applications in environmental communication. By understanding the nuances of framing in sustainability discourse, communicators can more effectively engage audiences and promote sustainable behaviors and policies.

Origins and Foundational Concepts

The application of framing theory to sustainability communication builds upon the broader theoretical foundations established by scholars in sociology, psychology, and communication studies. Erving Goffman's (1974) seminal work on frame analysis provided the groundwork for understanding how individuals organize their experiences and interpret information. In the realm of sustainability, this concept helps explain how people make sense of complex environmental issues and decide what actions, if any, to take.

Robert Entman's (1993) definition of framing as the selection and emphasis of certain aspects of perceived reality has been particularly influential in sustainability communication. His four functions of frames - defining problems, diagnosing causes, making moral judgments, and suggesting remedies - provide a useful framework for analyzing how environmental issues are communicated and understood.

Types of Frames in Sustainability Communication

Research in sustainability communication has identified several key types of frames that influence public perception and engagement with environmental issues:

Gain vs. Loss Frames: Building on Kahneman and Tversky's (1979) prospect theory, researchers have examined how framing environmental actions in terms of gains or losses affects behavior. Spence and Pidgeon (2010) found that gain frames were more effective in promoting positive attitudes towards climate change mitigation, while loss frames were more impactful when discussing adaptation strategies.

Individual vs. Collective Action Frames: These frames focus on whether environmental responsibility is portrayed as a personal or societal issue. Rickard et al. (2016) demonstrated that collective action frames were more effective in promoting pro-environmental behaviors among individuals with strong environmental values.

Present vs. Future Frames: The temporal framing of environmental issues can significantly impact engagement. McDonald et al. (2015) showed that emphasizing present (rather than future) impacts of climate change increased individuals' concern and willingness to act.

Local vs. Global Frames: The geographical scale at which environmental issues are presented can affect public response. Scannell and Gifford (2013) found that locally-framed climate change messages were more engaging and led to greater intentions to act among participants.

Gain vs. Loss Frames

The study by Spence and Pidgeon (2010) on the Effectiveness in Different Contexts reveals important nuances in how gain and loss frames work in sustainability communication. This research highlights a crucial distinction between mitigation strategies, which are actions aimed at reducing or preventing emissions of greenhouse gases, and adaptation strategies, which involve adjustments in natural or human systems in response to actual or expected climatic stimuli or their effects.

For mitigation efforts, the study found that gain frames were more effective. This means that presenting information in terms of the benefits achieved by taking action to reduce greenhouse gas emissions tends to be more persuasive. For example, a message framed in this way might state, "By switching to renewable energy sources, we can create new jobs, improve air quality, and ensure a sustainable future for our children." The effectiveness of gain frames in this context may be attributed to the fact that mitigation often involves long-term actions with benefits that may not be immediately apparent. Gain frames can help make these future benefits more tangible and motivating for the audience.

Conversely, when it comes to adaptation strategies, loss frames were found to be more impactful. This approach involves highlighting the negative consequences that will occur if no action is taken to adapt to climate change impacts. An example of this framing could be, "Failing to implement flood protection measures could lead to billions in property damage and displacement of coastal communities." The power of loss frames in adaptation contexts likely stems from the fact that adaptation often deals with more immediate and concrete risks. Loss frames can create a sense of urgency and motivate action to prevent these tangible losses.

The effectiveness of these frames is likely tied to several psychological factors. For mitigation, gain frames may reduce psychological distance, making the benefits feel more relevant and achievable. This can inspire hope and positive engagement, which is particularly important for long-term planning and benefits associated with mitigation efforts. On the other hand, for adaptation, loss frames may tap into loss aversion, which is people's tendency to prefer avoiding losses to acquiring equivalent gains. This can be a powerful motivator for immediate action, aligning well with the often more pressing timelines of adaptation measures.

The temporal aspects of climate issues also play a significant role in the effectiveness of these framing strategies. Mitigation typically involves long-term planning and benefits, which aligns well with gain frames that can inspire hope and positive engagement. Adaptation, however, frequently addresses more immediate concerns, where loss frames can effectively communicate urgency and risk.

These findings have significant practical implications for how we communicate about climate change. When discussing policies like carbon pricing or renewable energy investments, gain frames highlighting economic and health benefits might be more persuasive. For coastal planning or disaster preparedness, loss frames emphasizing potential damages could be more effective in motivating action.

While the study found distinct preferences for gain frames in mitigation and loss frames in adaptation, it's important to note that in practice, a combination of frames might be most effective. For comprehensive climate strategies, communicators might use gain frames to discuss overall mitigation goals, while using loss frames to address specific, immediate adaptation needs.

The effectiveness of these frames can also vary based on the audience. For policymakers focused on long-term planning, gain frames for mitigation might be particularly effective. For local communities facing immediate climate risks, loss frames for adaptation could be more impactful. Furthermore, cultural context plays a role in the reception of these frames. In some cultures, positive messaging (gain frames) might be generally preferred, while in others, direct communication about risks (loss frames) might be more culturally appropriate.

It's also crucial to consider the potential for message fatigue. Overuse of either frame can lead to disengagement. Constant use of loss frames for adaptation might lead to eco-anxiety or a

sense of helplessness. Exclusive use of gain frames for mitigation, on the other hand, might underplay the urgency of the climate crisis.

This research underscores the importance of tailoring communication strategies to the specific context of climate action. By carefully choosing between gain and loss frames based on whether the focus is on mitigation or adaptation, communicators can potentially increase the effectiveness of their messages and inspire more decisive climate action. This nuanced approach to framing can play a crucial role in engaging diverse audiences and driving meaningful progress in addressing climate change.

Individual vs Collective Action Frames

Individual vs. Collective Action Frames in sustainability communication represent a critical aspect of how environmental messages are constructed and received. This framing approach focuses on whether sustainability actions are presented as the responsibility of individuals or as collective efforts involving communities, organizations, or societies as a whole. Understanding the implications of these frames is crucial for effective environmental communication and fostering sustainable behaviors.

Individual action frames emphasize personal responsibility and the impact of individual choices on sustainability outcomes. These frames often highlight actions that individuals can take in their daily lives to reduce their environmental footprint. For example, messages might focus on personal choices such as reducing meat consumption, using public transportation, or installing energy-efficient appliances. The underlying premise of individual action frames is that cumulative individual efforts can lead to significant environmental improvements.

Research has shown that individual action frames can be effective in certain contexts. They can empower people by giving them a sense of agency and control over environmental issues. A study by Gifford and Comeau (2011) found that messages emphasizing personal efficacy in tackling climate change led to increased willingness to engage in pro-environmental behaviors. Individual action frames can also be particularly effective when targeting specific behaviors that are directly under personal control, such as recycling or energy conservation in the home.

However, individual action frames have limitations and potential drawbacks. Critics argue that these frames may inadvertently downplay the role of systemic changes and larger-scale policy interventions necessary for addressing complex environmental challenges. Focusing solely on individual actions might lead to what Maniates (2001) termed the "individualization of responsibility," potentially diverting attention from the need for collective action and policy changes.

Collective action frames, on the other hand, emphasize the role of community efforts, institutional changes, and societal-level interventions in addressing sustainability challenges. These frames highlight the interconnected nature of environmental issues and the need for coordinated responses. Examples of collective action frames include messages about

community-wide renewable energy projects, corporate sustainability initiatives, or international climate agreements.

The effectiveness of collective action frames is supported by various studies. For instance, Bain et al. (2016) found that framing climate change action in terms of collective benefits, such as economic development or a more caring community, was more effective in motivating support for pro-environmental policies than focusing on avoiding environmental risks. Collective frames can help overcome feelings of helplessness that individuals might experience when faced with global environmental challenges.

Moreover, collective action frames align well with the scale of many environmental problems. Issues like climate change, deforestation, or ocean pollution require coordinated efforts at local, national, and international levels. By emphasizing collective responsibility and action, these frames can foster a sense of shared purpose and mobilize broader support for sustainability initiatives.

However, collective action frames also have potential limitations. They may sometimes feel abstract or distant to individuals, potentially leading to a diffusion of responsibility. If people perceive environmental action as primarily the responsibility of governments or large organizations, they might be less inclined to take personal action.

The choice between individual and collective action frames often depends on the specific context, target audience, and communication goals. Some researchers argue for a balanced approach that combines both frames. For example, Rickard et al. (2016) suggest that messages that link individual actions to broader collective outcomes can be particularly effective. This approach acknowledges personal responsibility while also situating individual actions within a larger context of collective effort.

Cultural factors also play a role in the effectiveness of these frames. In more individualistic societies, individual action frames might resonate more strongly, while in more collectivist cultures, collective action frames might be more persuasive. Communicators need to be sensitive to these cultural nuances when crafting sustainability messages.

The temporal aspect of environmental issues also influences the choice of framing. For immediate, local issues, individual action frames might be more effective in spurring quick behavioral changes. For long-term, global challenges, collective action frames might be necessary to convey the scale of the problem and the need for systemic solutions.

Both individual and collective action frames have important roles to play in sustainability communication. Effective environmental messaging often requires a nuanced approach that recognizes the value of personal actions while also emphasizing the need for broader societal changes. By carefully considering the context, audience, and specific sustainability challenge, communicators can strategically employ these frames to maximize engagement and impact.

Ultimately, fostering a sense of both individual and collective responsibility may be key to addressing the complex environmental challenges we face.

Present vs. Future Frames

Present vs. Future Frames in sustainability communication represent a crucial dimension in how environmental issues and actions are presented to audiences. This framing approach focuses on whether sustainability challenges and their solutions are portrayed as immediate concerns or as future scenarios. The choice between present and future frames can significantly influence how individuals perceive, engage with, and respond to environmental messages.

Present frames in sustainability communication emphasize the current impacts and immediate relevance of environmental issues. These frames highlight ongoing environmental changes, existing threats to ecosystems and human well-being, and the urgent need for action. For instance, a present frame might focus on current extreme weather events, observable biodiversity loss, or existing pollution problems. The goal of present framing is to create a sense of immediacy and relevance, making environmental issues tangible and pressing for the audience.

Research has shown that present frames can be particularly effective in motivating action. A study by Spence et al. (2012) found that individuals who perceived climate change as a more immediate risk were more likely to express concern and willingness to take action. Present frames can help overcome psychological distance, a concept introduced by Trope and Liberman (2010) in their Construal Level Theory, which suggests that people tend to think more concretely about near-term events and more abstractly about distant ones.

The effectiveness of present frames is often attributed to their ability to create emotional engagement. By highlighting current impacts, these frames can evoke feelings of concern, empathy, or even urgency. For example, images of current wildfires or floods can create a visceral response that motivates immediate action. Additionally, present frames can leverage the principle of loss aversion, as described by Kahneman and Tversky (1979) in their Prospect Theory, by emphasizing existing or imminent losses due to environmental degradation.

However, present frames also have potential limitations. Overemphasis on current problems without presenting viable solutions can lead to feelings of helplessness or eco-anxiety. Moreover, for some environmental issues with longer-term impacts, present frames might not fully capture the scale or severity of future consequences.

Future frames, on the other hand, focus on long-term environmental projections, potential scenarios, and the consequences of current actions on future outcomes. These frames often involve presenting scientific models, future projections, or hypothetical scenarios. For example, a future frame might discuss sea-level rise predictions for 2100, potential biodiversity scenarios, or long-term climate change impacts.

The strength of future frames lies in their ability to provide a broader perspective on environmental issues. They can help individuals understand the long-term consequences of current behaviors and policies, potentially motivating more significant lifestyle changes or support for transformative policies. Future frames can also be effective in communicating the intergenerational aspects of sustainability, appealing to people's concern for future generations.

Research by Pahl et al. (2014) suggests that future frames can be particularly effective when combined with vivid, concrete examples that make future scenarios more tangible. This approach can help bridge the gap between abstract future projections and concrete present-day actions.

However, future frames also present challenges. The psychological distance associated with future events can make them feel less urgent or relevant to some audiences. There's a risk that future-focused messages might be perceived as speculative or uncertain, potentially reducing their impact. Additionally, for individuals struggling with immediate economic or social challenges, future environmental concerns might seem less pressing.

The choice between present and future frames often depends on various factors, including the specific environmental issue, target audience, and communication goals. Some researchers advocate for a balanced approach that combines both present and future perspectives. For instance, McDonald et al. (2015) found that messages linking current actions to future outcomes were effective in promoting pro-environmental behaviors.

The effectiveness of these frames can also vary based on cultural and individual differences. Some cultures may have a more future-oriented outlook, making future frames more resonant, while others might be more present-focused. Individual differences in temporal discounting – the tendency to value immediate rewards over future ones – can also influence the reception of these frames.

Moreover, the nature of the environmental issue itself can dictate the most appropriate temporal frame. For rapidly evolving problems like air pollution or water scarcity, present frames might be more effective. For slower, cumulative issues like climate change or biodiversity loss, a combination of present and future frames might be necessary to convey both immediate relevance and long-term significance.

In conclusion, both present and future frames play vital roles in sustainability communication. Present frames can create urgency and emotional engagement, motivating immediate action. Future frames provide perspective and can inspire long-term thinking and transformative changes. Effective sustainability communication often requires a nuanced approach that balances immediate concerns with long-term visions. By carefully considering the temporal aspects of environmental issues and tailoring messages accordingly, communicators can enhance the impact of their sustainability messages, fostering both immediate action and long-term commitment to environmental stewardship.

Local vs. Global Frames

Local vs. Global Frames in sustainability communication represent a significant dimension in how environmental issues are contextualized and presented to audiences. This framing approach focuses on whether sustainability challenges and their solutions are portrayed within a local, immediate context or as part of broader, global phenomena. The choice between local and global frames can substantially influence how individuals perceive, connect with, and respond to environmental messages.

Local frames in sustainability communication emphasize the immediate, tangible impacts of environmental issues within a specific community or region. These frames highlight how sustainability challenges affect local ecosystems, economies, and daily lives of people in a particular area. For instance, a local frame might focus on the effects of air pollution on a city's public health, the impact of deforestation on a nearby watershed, or the consequences of coastal erosion on a specific shoreline community. The goal of local framing is to make environmental issues personally relevant and concrete for the audience.

Research has consistently shown that local frames can be highly effective in engaging audiences and motivating action. A study by Scannell and Gifford (2013) found that locally-framed climate change messages were more effective in promoting climate change engagement than globally-framed messages. This effectiveness is often attributed to the concept of psychological proximity - the idea that people are more likely to engage with issues that feel close and personally relevant.

Local frames have several advantages in sustainability communication. They can create a strong sense of place attachment, which has been linked to increased pro-environmental behavior. By highlighting local impacts and solutions, these frames can also empower individuals and communities, fostering a sense of agency and efficacy. Moreover, local frames often provide concrete, relatable examples that can make complex environmental issues more accessible and understandable.

However, local frames also have potential limitations. They may sometimes fail to convey the full scope and interconnectedness of global environmental challenges. There's a risk that focusing solely on local issues might lead to a fragmented understanding of sustainability, potentially overlooking important global dynamics and interdependencies.

Global frames, on the other hand, present sustainability issues within a broader, worldwide context. These frames emphasize the interconnected nature of environmental challenges and the need for coordinated, international responses. For example, a global frame might discuss climate change as a planetary phenomenon, highlight the global implications of biodiversity loss, or focus on international efforts to combat ocean pollution.

The strength of global frames lies in their ability to convey the scale and complexity of environmental issues. They can help individuals understand how local actions contribute to and

are affected by global phenomena. Global frames are particularly effective in communicating the need for collective action and international cooperation in addressing sustainability challenges.

Research by Brügger et al. (2015) suggests that global frames can be especially impactful when they successfully link global issues to local concerns, helping individuals see how global environmental changes affect their lives and communities. This approach can bridge the gap between abstract global concepts and concrete personal experiences.

However, global frames also present challenges. The vastness and complexity of global issues can sometimes feel overwhelming, potentially leading to feelings of helplessness or disengagement. There's a risk that globally-framed messages might be perceived as distant or irrelevant to some audiences, particularly if they don't see a clear connection to their immediate lives.

The choice between local and global frames often depends on various factors, including the specific environmental issue, target audience, and communication goals. Many researchers and practitioners advocate for a balanced approach that combines both local and global perspectives. For instance, Wibeck (2014) argues for the importance of "glocal" framing, which connects global environmental issues to local contexts and vice versa.

The effectiveness of these frames can also vary based on cultural and individual differences. Some cultures may have a more globally-oriented outlook, making global frames more resonant, while others might be more locally focused. Individual differences in worldviews, values, and experiences can also influence the reception of these frames.

Moreover, the nature of the environmental issue itself can dictate the most appropriate spatial frame. For issues with clear local manifestations, like urban air pollution or local water scarcity, local frames might be more effective. For issues that are inherently global, like climate change or ozone depletion, a combination of global and local frames might be necessary to convey both the scale of the problem and its local relevance.

The use of local and global frames also intersects with other framing dimensions in sustainability communication. For instance, local frames often align well with present-focused and individual action frames, while global frames may pair effectively with future-oriented and collective action frames. Skillful communicators can leverage these intersections to create multi-dimensional, impactful messages.

Both local and global frames play crucial roles in sustainability communication. Local frames can create personal relevance and motivate immediate action, while global frames provide perspective and emphasize the need for collective, international efforts. Effective sustainability communication often requires a nuanced approach that balances local concerns with global awareness. By carefully considering the spatial aspects of environmental issues and tailoring messages accordingly, communicators can enhance the impact of their sustainability messages, fostering both local engagement and global understanding of environmental challenges.

Conclusion:

Framing theory offers a powerful lens through which to understand and improve sustainability communication. The four framing dimensions explored in this report - Gain vs. Loss, Individual vs. Collective Action, Present vs. Future, and Local vs. Global - demonstrate the complex and nuanced nature of environmental messaging. Each frame presents unique advantages and challenges, and their effectiveness can vary significantly depending on the specific context, target audience, and communication goals.

The research findings discussed throughout this report underscore the importance of a strategic and tailored approach to framing in sustainability communication. Effective communicators must carefully consider the interplay between different framing dimensions and how they align with the nature of the environmental issue at hand, cultural contexts, and individual differences among audience members.

Moving forward, the field of sustainability communication will benefit from continued research into the effectiveness of various framing strategies across diverse contexts and audiences. Additionally, exploring innovative ways to combine different framing approaches, such as "glocal" framing that bridges local and global perspectives, may yield more impactful communication strategies.

Ultimately, by leveraging the insights provided by framing theory, sustainability communicators can craft more engaging, persuasive, and actionable messages. This, in turn, can lead to increased public awareness, stronger support for environmental policies, and more widespread adoption of sustainable behaviors - all crucial elements in addressing the complex environmental challenges of our time.

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